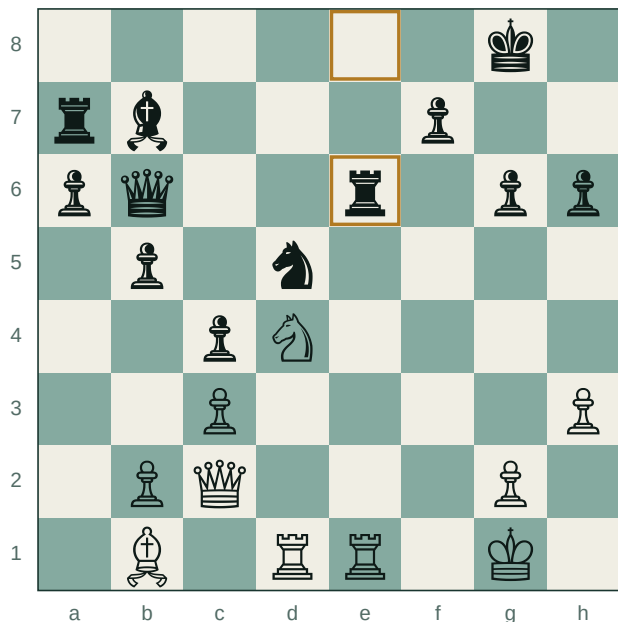


Capture the defender: White, move 28

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 27...Rxe6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

28. Rxe6 fxe6 29. Qxg6+

28.Rxe6 The rook captures the rook on e6. Recorded reply: **28...fxe6**.

29.Qxg6+ Check restricts Black to 2 legal replies here. The move also takes the pawn on g6.

At the end, nominal material is White 24 / Black 25 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +1: the balance goes from -2 to -1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g8. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.